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Presentation of business documents

Printed stationery

Fully blocked style with open punctuation

Continuous pages

Parts of a business letter 1.1–10

Open punctuation 1.11–16

Memos 1.17

Fax messages 1.18–19

Checklist

PRINTED STATIONERY

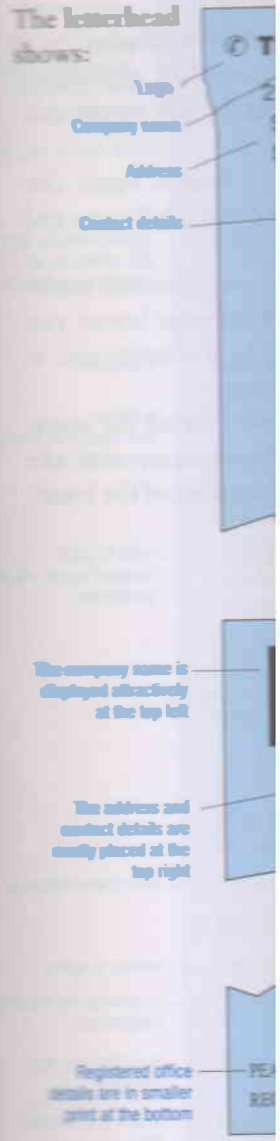
Attractive and consistent presentation of your business documents is vital if they are to make a good impression.

Your printed stationery should be of good quality, especially when being used for sending to external contacts. For internal documents the stationery does not need to be of such high quality.

The paper your company uses for its printed correspondence will express the personality of your company. Your letterhead will show:

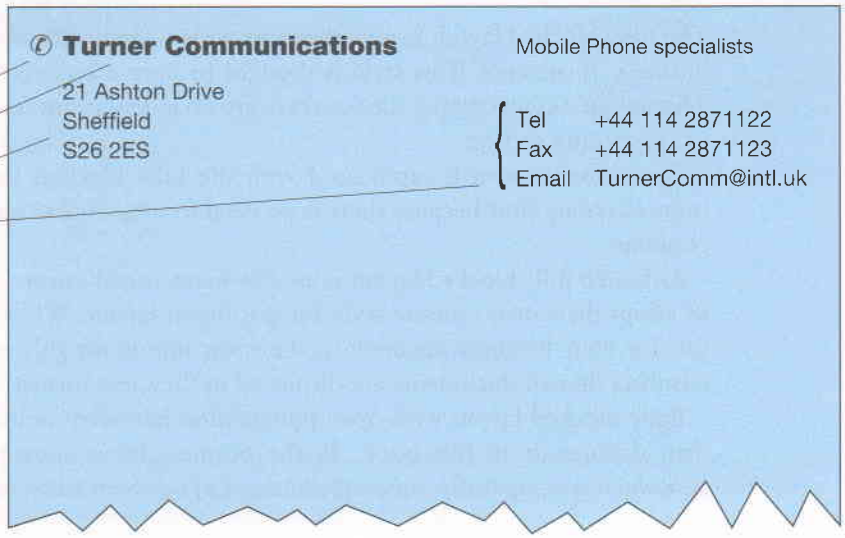
- a logo or graphic symbol identifying your company
- the company's name
- the full postal address
- contact numbers – telephone, fax, e-mail address
- the url or website address
- registered number or registered office. When the registered office is different to that shown in the address section, it is usual to show the registered address, normally at the foot of the notepaper, along with the registered number.

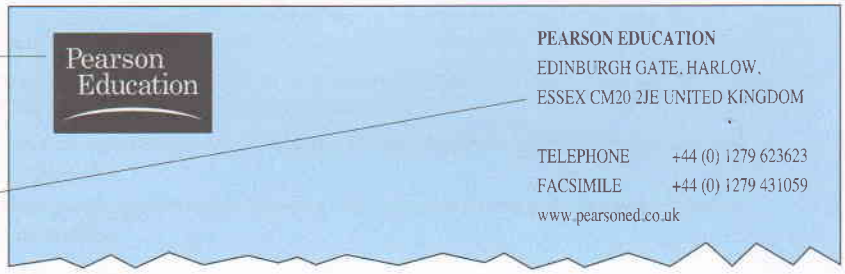
It is usual to engage experts to design a letterhead, especially an eye-catching logo with which the company can be identified.

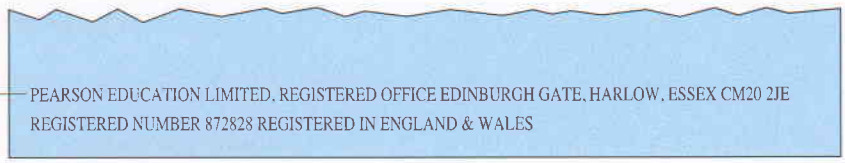


Here are two examples of letterheaded paper.

The letterhead shows:







FULLY BLOCKED STYLE WITH OPEN PUNCTUATION

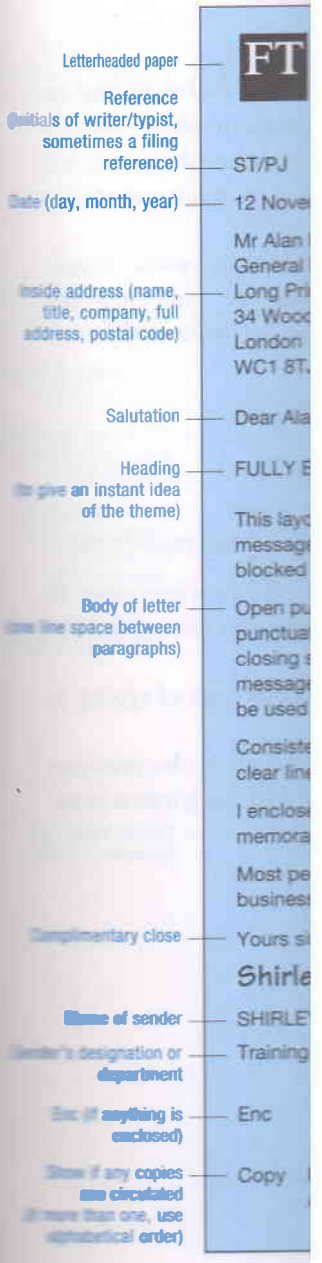
The fully blocked layout is now the most widely used method of display for all business documents. This style is thought to have a businesslike appearance. This layout reduces typing time as there are no indentations for new paragraphs or the closing section.

Open punctuation is often used with the fully blocked layout. Again this reduces typing time because there is no need for any unnecessary full stops and commas.

Although fully blocked layout is used by many organisations, some still prefer to adopt their own inhouse style for document layout. Whichever layout you use for your business documents, the most important rule is consistency, ie ensuring that all documents are displayed in the same format.

Fully blocked layout with open punctuation has been used for all the specimen documents in this book. In the business letter shown here, note the consistent spacing (only one single line space) between all sections of the letter.

TIP **The Chinese would say good presentation is good feng shui!**



Letterheaded paper

FT Prentice Hall
FINANCIAL TIMES

Financial Times Prentice Hall
Edinburgh Gate
Harlow, Essex
CM20 2JE
UNITED KINGDOM
Telephone: +44 (0)1279 623623
Facsimile: +44 (0)1279 431059

Reference (initials of writer/typist, sometimes a filing reference) — ST/PJ

Date (day, month, year) — 12 November 200—

Inside address (name, title, company, full address, postal code) —
Mr Alan Hill
General Manager
Long Printing Co Ltd
34 Wood Lane
London
WC1 8TJ

Salutation — Dear Alan

Heading (to give an instant idea of the theme) — FULLY BLOCKED LETTER LAYOUT

This layout has become firmly established as the most popular way of setting out letters, fax messages, memos, reports – in fact all business communications. The main feature of fully blocked style is that all lines begin at the left-hand margin.

Body of letter (one line space between paragraphs) —

Open punctuation is usually used with the fully blocked layout. This means that no punctuation marks are necessary in the reference, date, inside address, salutation and closing section. Of course essential punctuation must still be used in the text of the message itself. However, remember to use commas minimally today; they should be used only when their omission would make the sense of the message unclear.

Consistency is important in layout and spacing of all documents. It is usual to leave just one clear line space between each section.

I enclose some other examples of fully blocked layout as used in fax messages and memoranda.

Most people agree that this layout is very attractive and easy to produce as well as businesslike.

Complimentary close — Yours sincerely

Shirley Taylor

Name of sender — SHIRLEY TAYLOR (Miss)

Sender's designation or department — Training Specialist

Enc (if anything is enclosed) — Enc

Show if any copies are circulated (if more than one, use alphabetical order) — Copy Pradeep Jethi, Publisher
Amelia Lakin, Acquisitions Executive

CONTINUATION PAGES

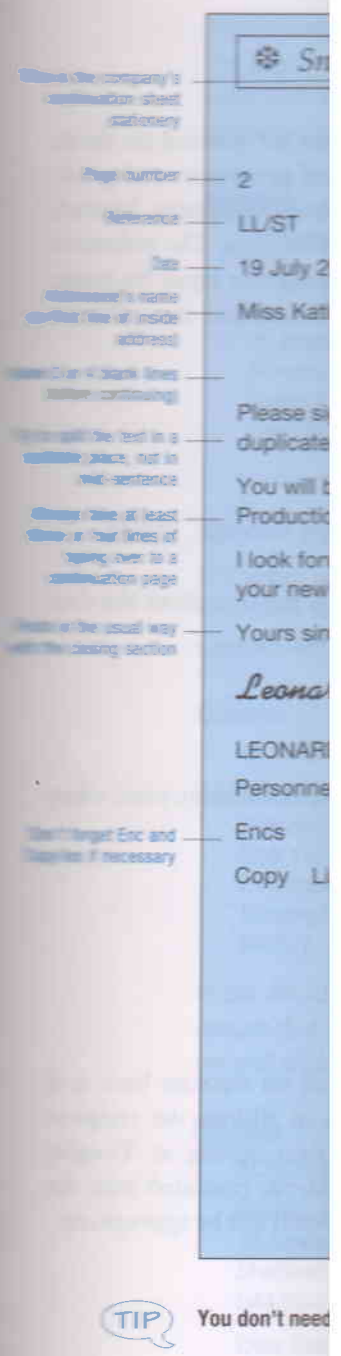
Some companies have printed continuation sheets that are used for second or subsequent pages of business letters. Such printed continuation sheets usually show just the company's name and logo. If printed continuation sheets are not available, the second or subsequent page should be typed on plain paper of a similar quality to that of the letterhead.

When a second or subsequent page is necessary, always include certain details at the top of the continuation sheet. These details are necessary for reference purposes in case the first and subsequent pages are separated in any way:

- page number
- date
- name of addressee.

When a continuation sheet is necessary, remember the following guidelines:

- It is not necessary to include anything at the foot of the previous page to indicate that a further page follows. The fact that there is no closing section or signature should make this quite obvious.
- A continuation page should contain at least three or four lines of typing as well as the usual closing section.
- Do not leave one line of a paragraph either at the bottom of the previous page or at the top of the next page. Try to start a new page with a new paragraph.



TIP You don't need

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n plain paper of a

lude certain details
are necessary for
e separated in any

wing guidelines:

e previous page to
s no closing section

r lines of typing as

om of the previous
ge with a new para-

This is the company's continuation sheet stationery

❄ *Snowflake Productions plc* *Continuation sheet*

Page number — 2

Reference — LL/ST

Date — 19 July 200---

Addressee's name (or first line of inside address) — Miss Katie Harford Hill

Leave 3 or 4 blank lines before continuing)

Please sign and return one copy of each of these documents and keep the duplicate copies for your reference.

Try to split the text in a suitable place, not in mid-sentence

You will be expected to attend an induction course on your first day at Snowflake Productions. A copy of the programme is enclosed.

Always take at least three or four lines of typing over to a continuation page

I look forward to meeting you again soon and hope that you will be very happy in your new post.

Yours sincerely — Resume in the usual way with the closing section

Leonard Leighton

LEONARD LEIGHTON

Personnel Director

Don't forget Enc and Copies if necessary — Encs

Copy Liz Walker, Training Manager

TIP **You don't need a line on which to sign your name. You get past that stage at five years old!**

PARTS OF A BUSINESS LETTER

1.1 Reference

In the past letterheads used to have 'Our ref' and 'Your ref' printed on them. Today this is rarely the case because with modern word processors and printers it is difficult to line up the printing on such pre-printed stationery. Instead, the typist normally inserts the reference on a line on its own. The reference includes the initials of the writer (usually in upper case) and the typist (in upper or lower case, as preferred). A file or departmental reference may also be included.

Examples

GBD/ST GBD/st/Per1 GBD/ST/134

1.2 Date

The date should always be shown in full. In the UK it is usual to show the date in the order day/month/year. No commas are used.

Example

12 July 2003

In some other countries the date is typed in the order month/day/year, often with a comma after the month.

Example

July 12, 2003

1.3 Inside address

The name and address of the recipient should be typed on separate lines as it would appear on an envelope. Care should be taken to address the recipient exactly as they sign their letters. For example, a person signing as 'Douglas Cowles' should be addressed as such in the inside address, preceded with the courtesy title 'Mr'. To address him as 'Mr D Cowles' would not be appropriate.

Example

Mr Douglas Cowles
General Manager
Cowles Engineering Co Ltd
12 Bracken Hill
Manchester
M60 8AS

When writing letters overseas, the name of the country should be shown on the final line of this section. As the letter will be sent by airmail, this should be indicated one clear line space above the inside address. Again note that the appropriate courtesy title (Mr/Mrs/Miss/Ms) should always be shown:

Example

AIRMAIL

Mr Doug Allen
Eagle Press Inc
24 South Bank
Toronto
Ontario
Canada M4J 7LK

1.4 Special markings

If a letter is confidential it is usual to include this as part of the inside address, one clear line space above it. This may be typed in upper case or in initial capitals with underscore.

Example

CONFIDENTIAL

Miss Iris Tan
Personnel Director
Soft Toys plc
21 Windsor Road
Birmingham
B2 5JT

Some decades ago an attention line was used when the writer simply wanted to ensure that the letter ended up on a certain person's desk, even though the letter was addressed to the company in general, and always began 'Dear Sirs'.

Example

FOR THE ATTENTION OF MR JOHN TAYLER, SALES MANAGER

Garden Supplies Ltd
24 Amber Street
Sheffield
S44 9DJ

Dear Sirs

In today's business letters, it should rarely be necessary to use an attention line. When you know the name of the person you are writing to, the name of the recipient should be included in the inside address, and a personalised salutation will be used.

1.5 Salutation

If the recipient's name has been used in the inside address, it is usual to use a personal salutation.

Example

Dear Mr Leighton Dear Douglas Dear Miss Tan Dear Rosehannah

If your letter is addressed generally to an organisation and not to a specific person, the more formal salutation 'Dear Sirs' should be used.

Example

Dear Sirs

If your letter is addressed to a head of department or the head of an organisation whose name is not known, then it would be more appropriate to use a salutation as shown here.

Example

Dear Sir or Madam

1.6 Heading

A heading gives a brief indication of the content of the letter. It is usually placed one clear line space after the salutation. Upper case is generally used, although initial capitals with underscore may be used if preferred.

Example

Dear Mrs Marshall

INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE – 24 AUGUST 2003

1.7 Complimentary close

It is customary to end the letter in a polite way by using a complimentary close. The two most common closes are 'Yours faithfully' (used only with Dear Sir/Sirs/Sir or Madam) and 'Yours sincerely' (used with personalised salutations).

Examples

Dear Sir Dear Sirs Dear Madam Dear Sir or Madam	Yours faithfully
Dear Mr Leighton Dear Mrs Yap Dear Caroline Dear Sam	Yours sincerely

1.8 Name of sender and designation

After the complimentary close 4 or 5 clear spaces should be left so that the letter can be signed. The name of the sender should then be inserted in whatever style is preferred – upper case, or initial capitals only. The sender's designation or department should be shown directly beneath his/her name. In these examples note that the title 'Mr' is never shown when the writer is male. However, it is usual to add a courtesy title for a female; this is shown in brackets after her name.

Examples

Yours faithfully	Yours sincerely
PATRICK ASHE Chairman	LESLEY BOLAN (Mrs) General Manager

When a letter has to be signed on behalf of the sender, it is usual to write 'for' or 'pp' in front of the sender's printed name; 'pp' is an abbreviation for per procurationem, which simply means 'on behalf of'.

Example

Yours faithfully

Shirley Johnson

for EDWARD NATHAN
Chairman

1.9 Enclosures

There are many different methods of indicating that an enclosure is being sent along with a letter:

- Affix a coloured 'enclosure' sticker usually in the bottom left-hand corner of the letter.
- Type three dots in the left-hand margin on the line where the enclosure is mentioned in the body of the letter.
- Type 'Enc' or 'Encs' at the foot of the letter, leaving one clear line space after the sender's designation. This is the most common form of indicating enclosures.

Example

Yours sincerely

LINDA PATERSON (Mrs)
Marketing Manager

Enc

1.10 Copies

When a copy of a letter is to be sent to a third party (usually someone in the sender's organisation) this may be indicated by typing 'cc' (copy circulated or courtesy copy) or 'Copy' followed by the name and designation of the copy recipient. If there are two or more copy recipients, it is usual to show these in alphabetical order.

Example

Copy Ravi Gopal, General Manager
Ashley Ow Yong, Company Secretary
Candice Reeves, Accountant

If the writer does not wish the recipient of the letter to know that a third person is receiving a copy of the letter, then 'bcc' (blind courtesy copy) is used. This should not be shown on the top of the letter, only on the file copy and bcc copy/ies.

Example

bcc Mr Gordon Clark, Chief Executive



Don't send a cc to everyone you know – just send them to people who need to know.

OPEN PUNCTUATION

Open punctuation is commonly used with fully blocked layout. Only punctuation marks that are essential to ensure good grammatical sense are included within the main body of the message itself. All other commas and full stops are omitted, especially in the presentational aspects like the date, inside address, etc.



With commas, the rule is now less rather than more.

1.11 Dates

	NOT
25 September 2003	25th September, 2003
14 July 2004	July 14th, 2004

1.12 Names and addresses

Mr G P Ashe
Chief Executive
Ashe Publications Pte Ltd
#03-45 Ashe Towers
212 Holland Avenue
Singapore 2535

no full stops

no commas at the end of lines

1.13 Salutation

Dear Patrick

no comma

1.14 Complimentary close

Yours sincerely

no comma

1.15 Abbreviations

		NOT	
Mr	eg	Mr.	e.g.
Dr	ie	Dr.	i.e.
BA	pm	B.A.	p.m.
IBM	am	I.B.M.	a.m.
MRT		M.R.T.	
NB		N.B.	
PS		P.S.	

1.16 Times and numbers

		NOT	
9.30 am		9.30 a.m.	9.30am
0950		09.50 am	
1400		14:00	
1	8	1.	8)
2	9	2.	9)
3	10	3.	10)



Use open punctuation and remove a lot of the clutter from your writing and presentation.